

MUJEEB FARUQUI

RENEWED REMIT A NABH certification will be costly for small private nursing homes

▶ MADHYA PRADESH

An Ill Conceived Measure

A tweak in PMJAY rules risks excluding small private nursing homes

By **Rahul Noronha**

AYUSHMAN BHARAT HAS SET AN AMBUSH on small health providers in Madhya Pradesh. The health department wants all private hospitals empanelled under the Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana (PMJAY) in Bhopal, Indore, Gwalior and Jabalpur to get certified by the National Accreditation Board for Hospitals (NABH).

Minus that, the directive states, they would be ineligible to stay under PMJAY. At stake is the treatment of the poorest of the poor, who usually rely on small private nursing homes providing Ayushman benefits. The scheme enables this by paying empanelled hospitals specified rates for procedures.

'DISCRIMINATORY ORDER'

Private nursing homes are up in arms and have moved the MP High Court against the order. The four cities named are the state's top destinations for PMJAY patients, with 321 empanelled private nursing homes. Only 106 are NABH-certified, which, they say, is voluntary. In fact, PMJAY guidelines allow this with a graded payment—NABH ones get paid 25 per cent extra.

MP is the only state that has made NABH compulsory, that too in selected cities. "The order is discriminatory. States like Delhi and Kerala don't ask for NABH," says Dr Pushpraj Bhatele, an intervener in the case. Also, many public hospitals under PMJAY are not NABH-certified. "Why different yardsticks?" asks a nursing home owner.

One answer suggests itself: the beneficiaries would be bigger corporate hospitals. Securing NABH certification is costly. A 25-bed hospital can't afford to invest Rs 1 crore for it—that's just for a two-year entry-level sanction. In a big hospital, patient costs, too, shoot up; PMJAY picks up only part of the tab.

Takeaways

- **Pvt. hospitals protest new PMJAY precondition**
- **Favours big corporate hospitals, hits the poor**

Deputy CM Rajendra Shukla, in charge of health, sought to calm the waters on April 15, with a six-month extension of deadline. These cities, he tells INDIA TODAY, had "the most number of new hospitals". ■

By **Dhaval S. Kulkarni**

RELATIONSHIP GONE SOUR? A BUNCH OF boardroom predators, abusing their professional power? Or a larger design aimed at entrapment and religious conversions? A case rife with dire allegations, and potentially more than one victim and aggressor, has exploded in what would seem an unlikely venue: a Tata Consultancy Services (TCS) office in Nashik.

The tech giant has found the storm so damaging that it has shut operations at the BPO, asking its employees to work from home instead. This was after Tata Sons chairman N. Chandrasekaran made a statement, calling the complaints "gravely concerning and anguishing", even as it scaled up to a full-blown political slugfest, parties moving in to weaponise the case.

'CABAL OF BULLIES'

Questions swirl around the cases, meanwhile, as social media darkens with invective. The nine FIRs filed relate to a welter of charges, prima facie confusing. But all centre around an alleged cabal who are said to have abused their senior positions by forming a bully group. Besides rape on pretext of marriage or for a job, they stand charged with sexual harassment at the workplace, and hurting religious sentiments. Seven of the accused have been arrested, one is at large.

The unravelling began this February, as a political activist approached Nashik police claiming a Hindu woman working in the local TCS BPO had been "manipulated", and was seen observing the Ramzan fast. The police penetrated the organisation by placing some of its personnel as housekeeping staff, then swooped in to take action.

The first FIR was registered at Deolali Camp police station by a victim who was in a relationship with one of the accused, Danish Shaikh. He's said to have concealed his